

The Christian's Standing and Daily Walk

Justified in Christ, Yet Battling the Flesh

The Tension Every Believer Feels

One of the greatest tensions in the Christian life is understanding how a believer can be completely forgiven and justified in Christ while at the same time remaining painfully aware of sin in daily experience. Many sincere Christians wrestle deeply with this issue:

How can I be completely forgiven and justified in Christ, and yet still struggle with sin in my daily walk?

The New Testament answers both realities without weakening either one.

These biblical truths are self-evident:

- **Romans 6** — the believer has died with Christ to sin's dominion.
- **Romans 8:1** — there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.
- **Colossians 2:13** — all trespasses have been forgiven through Christ.
- **1 John 1:8** — believers still experience the presence of sin.
- **Galatians 5:17** — the flesh and the Spirit continue to oppose one another.
- **Romans 7** — the believer can experience this conflict deeply.

The error comes when Christians confuse two distinct truths:

- our standing before God,
- and our daily fellowship and walk with God.

The gospel preserves both without contradiction.

¹ *Unless otherwise noted, all Scripture quotations in this paper are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB).*

The Believer's Standing Before God Never Changes

If a person is truly in Christ, then before the Father he is:

- justified (Romans 5:1),
- accepted in the Beloved (Ephesians 1:6),
- reconciled (Colossians 1:21–22),
- crucified with Christ (Galatians 2:20),
- raised with Christ (Colossians 3:1),
- and seated with Christ in heavenly places (Ephesians 2:6).

“In Christ” therefore means “no condemnation” (Romans 8:1).

The believer's acceptance before God is not fluctuating based upon daily performance. Christ has accomplished what the believer could never accomplish for himself.

The Christian is not on probation before God. He is not gradually becoming acceptable to God through progressive improvement. His acceptance rests upon Christ, not upon his daily performance (Ephesians 1:6).

This is why continual self-condemnation is spiritually dangerous. It can subtly shift the believer's confidence away from the finished work of Christ and toward personal performance.

The cross did not merely provide forgiveness for individual acts of sin. Through union with Christ in His death and resurrection, the believer has entered an entirely new position before God (Romans 6:6–11).

This does not teach sinless perfection. Scripture nowhere teaches that sin is eradicated from the believer's flesh in this life. Rather, it teaches that the believer's former relationship to sin's dominion has been decisively broken through union with Christ.

Yet Sin Remains Present in the Flesh

At the same time, Scripture never teaches that sin has been eradicated from the believer's flesh during this present life.

The presence of sin is not the same thing as slavery to sin.

Paul openly says:

“In that case, it is no longer I who do it, but it is sin living in me.” — Romans 7:17

And:

“For the flesh craves what is contrary to the Spirit, and the Spirit what is contrary to the flesh.”
— Galatians 5:17

The mature believer does not necessarily become less aware of sin. Often, he becomes more aware of it because spiritual light increasingly exposes the corruption that remains within fallen flesh.

Yet this is the crucial distinction:

The believer no longer relates to sin as a condemned slave, but as a justified child of God who now hates what once ruled him (Romans 6:6–11; Romans 7:15).

That changes everything.

Before conversion:

- sin was master (Romans 6:17),
- sin characterized the old life (Ephesians 2:1–3),
- sinful desires governed the heart (John 3:19).

Now:

- sin is an intruder,
- sin is an enemy,
- sin is inconsistent with who the believer is in Christ (2 Corinthians 5:17).

The Christian may still battle sin, but he no longer belongs to sin's dominion (Romans 6:14).

The Indwelling Holy Spirit and the Christian Life

The Christian life is not merely the result of understanding doctrinal truths; it is the result of the Holy Spirit applying those truths in daily experience.

When a person trusts Christ, God not only justifies him but also gives him the indwelling presence of the Holy Spirit (Romans 8:9; 1 Corinthians 6:19). The believer is therefore never left to fight the battle against sin in his own strength.

This is one reason the Christian life becomes so frustrating when approached through self-effort. The flesh cannot overcome the flesh. Human determination, religious discipline, and personal resolutions cannot produce the righteousness God desires.

Paul therefore writes:

“So I say, walk by the Spirit, and you will not gratify the desires of the flesh.” — Galatians 5:16

The answer to indwelling sin is not greater confidence in self, but greater dependence upon the Spirit of God.

The Holy Spirit works within the believer to:

- reveal sin and produce conviction (John 16:8; Galatians 5:16–17),
- direct the heart toward Christ (John 16:14),
- illuminate Scripture (1 Corinthians 2:12–14),
- strengthen obedience (Ezekiel 36:27; Galatians 5:16),
- and produce spiritual fruit (Galatians 5:22–23).

The Christian's victory over sin is therefore not found in striving to improve the old nature, but in yielding to the Spirit who enables him to walk in the reality of his new position in Christ.

This does not mean the struggle disappears. Galatians 5:17 teaches that the flesh and the Spirit continue to oppose one another. Yet the believer no longer fights alone. The same Spirit who raised Christ from the dead now dwells within him (Romans 8:11).

Thus, the Christian life is not simply Christ *for us* at the cross, glorious as that truth is. It is also Christ *in us* through the Holy Spirit, empowering us to walk in fellowship with God and progressively conforming us to the image of Christ (Romans 8:29).

The Biblical Response to Sin

How then should believers respond to the continuing reality of sin in their lives?

The biblical answer is neither denial nor despair. Scripture calls believers to honesty, confession, repentance, dependence upon Christ, and continual faith in the gospel (1 John 1:9; Acts 20:21).

Many Christians fear that acknowledging complete forgiveness in Christ will produce carelessness toward sin. Paul anticipated this objection:

“What then shall we say? Shall we continue in sin so that grace may increase? Certainly not!” — Romans 6:1–2

Grace does not produce indifference toward sin. In fact, grace teaches believers to reject ungodliness and worldly passions and to live self-controlled, upright, and godly lives (Titus 2:11–12).

Many sincere believers become so occupied with the corruption still present within the flesh that Christ Himself no longer remains central in their spiritual vision. Scripture certainly calls Christians to honesty about sin, yet the believer's primary focus is not meant to rest upon self, but upon Christ (Hebrews 12:2).

Paul fully acknowledged the presence of indwelling sin:

“I know that nothing good lives in me, that is, in my flesh.” — Romans 7:18

Yet Paul did not live under continual self-condemnation. After describing the painful struggle of Romans 7, he immediately triumphs in Christ:

“Thanks be to God, through Jesus Christ our Lord!” — Romans 7:25

And then:

“Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus.” — Romans 8:1

The mature Christian learns to acknowledge the reality of the flesh without allowing the flesh to eclipse the finished work of Christ. The believer's confidence rests not in personal progress, but in union with the risen Christ (Colossians 3:1–3).

The believer's focus must ultimately rest not upon self, but upon Christ.

The Meaning of Confession

Many believers wonder whether they should continue asking God for forgiveness if all sins have been fully dealt with through Christ's finished work.

The answer requires careful distinction.

First John 1:9 says:

“If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness.”

Confession, however, must not be understood as re-earning judicial forgiveness or reestablishing justification before God. The believer is not repeatedly saved anew each time he confesses sin.

Rather, confession means agreeing with God about sin. It is the honest acknowledgment of sin before the Father.

The Christian therefore does not come to God as a criminal terrified of eternal judgment, but as a child seeking restored fellowship with his Father (Romans 8:15; Galatians 4:6).

Because the believer already stands justified in Christ (Romans 5:1), confession is not an attempt to regain acceptance with God, but the humble response of one who desires to walk honestly in the light (1 John 1:7–9).

Judicial Forgiveness and Relational Cleansing

This distinction is enormously helpful.

Judicial forgiveness is once-for-all. Through the sacrifice of Christ, the believer's standing before God has been permanently secured (Hebrews 10:14).

The believer will never again come into condemnation (Romans 8:1).

Yet Scripture also teaches the ongoing need for cleansing within fellowship with God. In John 13:10, Jesus told Peter:

“The one who has been washed has no need to wash anything except his feet; his whole body is clean.”

The believer is already clean in his standing in Christ, yet still requires daily cleansing in practical fellowship.

Confession therefore restores fellowship, tenderness of heart, openness before God, and freedom of conscience (1 John 1:7–9). It does not restore lost justification, because justification was never lost.

This understanding preserves both assurance and holiness.

Asking Forgiveness in Prayer

Some Christians avoid the phrase “forgive me” altogether because they fear it contradicts complete forgiveness in Christ. Yet Scripture consistently portrays believers approaching God in repentance, humility, confession, and dependence (1 John 1:9; Hebrews 4:16).

The issue is not necessarily the words themselves, but the theology behind them.

If a believer says, “Forgive me,” meaning, *“I fear I am no longer justified unless You judicially pardon me again,”* then such thinking undermines the finished work of Christ (Hebrews 10:14).

However, if the believer means, *“Father, I acknowledge my sin and seek cleansing, restored fellowship, and help,”* then the prayer is entirely consistent with biblical repentance and confession (Psalm 51:1–4).

The heart posture matters greatly.

The believer does not come to God as a criminal attempting to regain acceptance, but as a child returning honestly to his Father (Luke 15:18–20). Confession is not an effort to persuade God to love us again, but the humble response of one who already stands accepted in Christ (Ephesians 1:6).

Thus the Christian can confess sin freely and honestly without fear of condemnation, knowing that Christ has already borne the full judgment for sin at the cross (Romans 8:1).

Maintaining a Clear Conscience

A clear conscience is not maintained by pretending sin does not exist (1 John 1:8). Nor is it maintained through constant self-condemnation (Romans 8:1).

Rather, a clear conscience comes through:

- honest acknowledgment of sin,
- confession (1 John 1:9),
- faith in Christ's finished work (Hebrews 10:14),
- and continual walking in the light (1 John 1:7).

The healthy believer says with Paul:

“I know that nothing good lives in me, that is, in my flesh.” — Romans 7:18

Yet he also says:

“Who shall bring any charge against God’s elect?” — Romans 8:33

Both statements are simultaneously true.

The believer fully agrees with God about the corruption of the flesh while also fully resting in the perfect acceptance found in Christ.

A Balanced Christian Life

The mature Christian life is marked by a continual rhythm of repentance and faith (Acts 20:21).

The believer becomes:

- quick to confess (1 John 1:9),
- quick to repent (Revelation 3:19),
- quick to reject condemnation (Romans 8:1),
- quick to depend upon the Holy Spirit (Galatians 5:16),
- and increasingly occupied with Christ rather than self (Hebrews 12:2).

Sanctification is not the process of becoming gradually acceptable to God. Rather, it is the process of learning to walk consistently in the reality of an acceptance already fully secured in Christ (Ephesians 1:6).

The believer does not strive toward sonship; he lives from sonship (1 John 3:1–2).

Thus, the Christian no longer says:

“I must become worthy.”

Instead, he says:

“Because I already belong to Christ, I desire to walk worthy of Him.” — Ephesians 4:1

Conclusion

The gospel holds together two truths that must never be separated: the believer is fully justified in Christ (Romans 5:1), and yet still experiences the presence of indwelling sin in daily life (Galatians 5:17).

The cross settled forever the believer's standing before God. There is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus (Romans 8:1). The believer has died with Christ and been freed from sin's dominion through union with Him (Romans 6:6–7).

At the same time, Christians still battle the flesh and therefore must live lives marked by honesty, confession, repentance, dependence upon Christ, and continual faith (1 John 1:9; Galatians 5:16).

Nor has God left believers to fight this battle in their own strength. Through the indwelling Holy Spirit, God works within His children to convict of sin, direct their hearts toward Christ, strengthen obedience, and produce spiritual fruit (Galatians 5:22–23; Romans 8:13–14).

The Christian life is therefore not a struggle for victory through self-effort, but a walk of dependence upon the Spirit who applies the realities of our union with Christ in daily experience.

Confession is not a repeated attempt to secure justification, but the ongoing response of a child who desires unhindered fellowship with his Father (1 John 1:7–9).

The believer's peace ultimately rests not in personal performance, but in the finished work of Jesus Christ (Hebrews 10:14). Because of that finished work, Christians are free to face their sin honestly without fear of condemnation and free to walk before God with both humility and confidence (Hebrews 4:16).

Indeed, one evidence of genuine spiritual life is that the believer increasingly hates the very sins he once loved. The conflict itself is not proof that he is lost, but can be evidence that the Spirit of God is at work within him. The presence of inward warfare is not the mark of a heart at peace with sin, but of a heart that belongs to Christ. Like Paul, the believer may grieve over his failures and cry out against the sin that remains in his flesh, yet he does so as one whose deepest desire is to please God (Romans 7:15, 22).

Though the believer may stumble many times, he cannot be comfortable in sin as he once was, for God has given him new desires and a new relationship to sin itself. What once ruled him, he now resists; what once pleased him, he now grieves over. And while the struggle continues until glorification, the victory has already been secured through union with Jesus Christ our Lord.

Therefore, the Christian's confidence rests not in the strength of his devotion, the consistency of his obedience, or the intensity of his repentance, but in the Savior who loved him, died for him, rose again for him, and now lives for him.

Fixing his eyes upon Christ, he walks forward in humility, gratitude, and hope, knowing:

“being confident of this, that He who began a good work in you will continue to perfect it until the day of Christ Jesus.” — Philippians 1:6

This is the balance of the Christian life: fully accepted in Christ, yet still being transformed by His Spirit; honest about the flesh, yet confident in grace; aware of sin, yet free from condemnation; dependent not upon self, but upon Christ.

